CANDIDATE BRIEFING · 8 AUGUST 2026

The HSBC Relationship Manager Role — Explained Simply

Contents

For: Janak · **Prepared:** 10 August 2026 · **Style:** plain English, every technical term explained on first use and again in the glossary. Written to help you build *genuine* interest in the client-facing role and talk about it credibly.

Why this is for you. You said you like client-facing roles. In Corporate and Institutional Banking, the client-facing job *is* the Relationship Manager — the person who owns the client, understands their business, and brings the whole bank to them. This guide walks the role end to end, then opens up the two technical machines behind it that candidates almost never understand — **checking who a client really is** (the anti-money-laundering and "know your customer" process) and **looking after investors' assets** (asset servicing) — and finishes with an honest, specific answer to "why HSBC."

Tags: OFFICIAL = from HSBC or a regulator · CORROBORATED = several reliable sources agree · ANECDOTAL = single/weaker source · INFERRED = my plain-English explanation, not a quoted fact. Bracketed numbers like [1] link to the source list. Plain teaching text has no tag.

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1. What a Relationship Manager actually is

Think of the Relationship Manager — HSBC also calls this a **coverage banker** or **Global Relationship Manager** — as the **quarterback** for a set of client companies. They don't personally run the payments, do the trading, or issue the loans. Their job is to **understand the client deeply, own the relationship, and pull in the right specialists** to solve the client's problems. HSBC describes its Banking teams as **"a single coverage point for multi-national clients"** whose sector-focused relationship managers **"connect clients to the products and services that meet their international financial needs."** OFFICIAL [1]

In HSBC's own words, the role gives **"dedicated relationship management to a portfolio of customers with accountability for sales, service, risk and operational delivery,"** acting as **"a strategic advisor"** to **"deepen the Bank's wallet"** and **"grow international and cross-border revenue."** OFFICIAL [1] *"Wallet"* here just means how much of a client's total banking business HSBC wins — "growing wallet" means selling that client more of what it needs.

Who they work with (the specialists they call in): OFFICIAL [2] - **Global Trade Solutions** — the trade-finance team (helping clients buy and sell across borders safely). - **Global Payments Solutions** — the payments and cash-management team (moving and controlling money worldwide). - **Markets and Securities Services** — the trading team (currencies, interest rates) and the asset-servicing team (see Part 6). - **Financing, capital markets and advisory** — for loans, bond and share sales, and deal advice. - Plus internal control partners: **Credit, Risk, Legal, and Compliance / Financial Crime.**

Graduate/analyst versus senior Relationship Manager: OFFICIAL [1] - As a **graduate or analyst**, you **"support relationship bankers and coverage teams,"** do the **research and financial analysis**, help draft **credit applications** (the write-up that asks the bank to approve a loan), prepare pitches, and work alongside Legal, Credit and Risk. You are learning the clients and the products. - A **senior Relationship Manager** owns the relationship, leads the strategic conversations, carries the revenue target, and signs off on how deals are structured — while being responsible, in HSBC's words, to **"safeguard the Group from potential loss."** OFFICIAL [1]

This is a genuinely **client-facing, commercial, analytical, relationship-building** role — which is exactly the mix HSBC says it selects for. INFERRED, from HSBC's six listed relationship-manager skills[1]

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2. The client lifecycle, end to end (the core process)

This is how a relationship actually runs, from first contact to renewal. HSBC doesn't publish it as neat numbered steps, so the **sequence** below is the standard corporate-banking lifecycle, with HSBC's own descriptions dropped in where they exist. CORROBORATED sequence; OFFICIAL where quoted[1] [22]

Stage 1 — Finding the client (prospecting). The Relationship Manager, helped by the analyst's research, identifies target companies — often by industry sector, or by a cross-border "corridor" (for example, a company expanding from the United Kingdom into Asia) — and works out what they'll need.

Stage 2 — Winning the client (pitching). The team builds a pitch showing HSBC's value — its network, product range and pricing — and negotiates. HSBC lists **"sales pitching and prospecting — explaining value and negotiating deals"** as a core skill. OFFICIAL [1]

Stage 3 — Onboarding: checking the client and assessing credit. This is the friction-heavy stage, and it's where the technical machinery in Part 5 lives. Before HSBC can do business, it must **verify who the client really is** (the "know your customer" and anti-money-laundering checks) *and* **assess whether it's safe to lend to them** (the credit assessment). HSBC's own relationship-manager job description demands **"adherence to know-your-customer guidelines, anti-money-laundering regulations, and financial-crime risk-management standards,"** and, in parallel, that the banker **"prepare credit applications including industry analysis, financial analysis, cash projections, and trade-cycle assessments."** OFFICIAL [7]

Stage 4 — Designing the solution (structuring and pricing). The Relationship Manager shapes the deal — the size of a loan, its conditions (called **covenants** — promises the borrower makes, like keeping debt below a certain level), and the price — so it earns the bank an acceptable return. HSBC: the banker must **"make appropriate facility structure recommendations."** OFFICIAL [7] *("Facility" is just banking jargon for a credit arrangement — a loan or line of credit.)*

Stage 5 — Widening the relationship (cross-selling). The Relationship Manager brings in the specialist teams to sell more of what the client needs — payments, trade finance, currency hedging, asset servicing — turning a single-product client into a deep, multi-product relationship. HSBC requires **"close liaison with colleagues from other lines of business, products and services."** OFFICIAL [7]

Stage 6 — Getting it approved and live (credit approval and execution). The credit write-up goes to a **credit committee** (senior risk people who approve or decline); once approved, the legal documents are signed and the facilities go live. The banker's duty is to **"safeguard the Group from potential loss and minimise the risk of losses from bad debts."** OFFICIAL [7]

Stage 7 — Looking after the account (monitoring). The Relationship Manager services the relationship, watches the client's financial health, and checks it is keeping to its covenants — HSBC frames this as overseeing **"the credit risk associated with assigned client relationships"** and delivering **"a consistent, cohesive client experience."** OFFICIAL [1]

Stage 8 — The annual review (growing the relationship). Each year the loans are renewed and the relationship is reviewed: Is the client profitable for the bank? How much of its business do we have? Where can we grow? HSBC's stated aim is **"deepening the Bank's wallet."** OFFICIAL [1]

Stage 9 — Renewal and expansion. Facilities renew, limits grow, and new products and new countries get added as the client expands — which loops straight back to Stage 1 for the next opportunity.

Who's involved throughout: the Relationship Manager and analyst up front (the **"first line"**), the onboarding and know-your-customer teams in the middle, and Credit, Risk and Compliance as the control functions. (That structure has a name — the "three lines of defence" — explained in Part 5.) INFERRED / OFFICIAL functions named [7]

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3. How HSBC does this differently

A domestic bank can bank a company in one country. HSBC's whole pitch is that it can **follow a client across the world as one bank.** Here's what's genuinely distinctive:

- **"One client, one bank" across the network.** HSBC serves around **41 million customers across 56 markets** OFFICIAL [6] and tells clients the network **"isn't just a fact, it's a capability."** The proof point it uses: **62% of its revenue comes from clients it banks in more than one country** OFFICIAL — Euromoney citing HSBC, 2025[15]. A local bank simply can't follow a client abroad the same way — this is the core differentiator.
- **The East–West corridor.** HSBC is built around **two international financial centres — Hong Kong and the United Kingdom** — and positions itself to capture the **trade and money flows between East and West** as supply chains shift. It is **present across about 86% of global trade** and moves **more than $800 billion of trade flows a year.** OFFICIAL [3]
- **Global plus local coverage.** A global relationship manager owns the top of the relationship, while local managers in each country look after the client's local operations — so the client gets "one bank" globally but real people on the ground locally. INFERRED from HSBC's "single coverage point … local knowledge"[1]
- **Sector specialists,** including a dedicated **Innovation Banking** team for venture-capital-backed technology and life-science companies. OFFICIAL [4]
- **Sustainability / transition finance** — helping clients **decarbonise** (reduce their carbon emissions) is now a live part of the relationship conversation. OFFICIAL [4]
- **Technology the client actually touches — HSBCnet** (the online banking portal for big companies) and **TradePay** (digital trade finance), which HSBC says **"supports nearly $8 billion in limits across thousands of large corporates"** and was quickly adapted to help clients manage new United States tariffs. OFFICIAL [15]
- **The 2024–25 simplification.** HSBC merged its old corporate and investment banks into one **Corporate and Institutional Banking** division (effective 1 January 2025), explicitly to **"eliminate silos,"** give clients one coverage experience, and **speed up onboarding.** OFFICIAL [5]

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4. Facts and figures worth knowing

- **Corporate and Institutional Banking earned about $27–28 billion of revenue in 2025** (the first half alone was **$14.1 billion** — the solid, quotable figure) and is the **biggest single profit contributor** in the group OFFICIAL 1H25; FY2025 to verify[11].

- **Wholesale transaction banking** (the payments-and-trade fee engine) earned about **$10.9 billion** in 2025 OFFICIAL, verify[10].
- **62%** of group revenue comes from clients banked in **more than one country** OFFICIAL — Euromoney/HSBC 2025[15].
- **Number one trade-finance bank in the world for nine years running**; **more than 10,000 people** in the division; **160 years** of heritage. OFFICIAL[3]
- **Four client types: Global Corporates** (the biggest multinationals), **Institutions** (banks, insurers, investors, governments), **International Mid-Market** (medium-sized firms going cross-border), and **Innovation Banking** (start-ups and scale-ups). OFFICIAL[3]

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5. The technical machine, part one: knowing who your client really is

This is the part most candidates can't explain — and if you can, you stand out. It also happens to be central to the Relationship Manager's job, because *they* are the first person responsible for it.

What the problem is

Money laundering is taking money made from crime — drugs, fraud, corruption, trafficking — and passing it through the banking system so it comes out looking clean and legal. It usually happens in three steps: CORROBORATED[20] - **Placement** — the dirty cash first enters the system (for example, deposited into an account). - **Layering** — it's moved through many transactions and companies to hide the trail. - **Integration** — it comes back to the criminal as apparently legitimate money (property, business income).

Governments make banks the **gatekeepers** and require them, by law, to stop this. The rules come from the **Bank Secrecy Act** in the United States, the **Money Laundering Regulations** and **Proceeds of Crime Act** in the United Kingdom, and a global standard-setter called the **Financial Action Task Force**. Get it wrong and a bank faces criminal charges, fines in the billions, and the loss of its licence. CORROBORATED[20]

The key terms, in plain English CORROBORATED[20] [21]

- **Know Your Customer** — the duty to genuinely know who you're dealing with, and to keep knowing throughout the relationship.
- **Customer Due Diligence** — the baseline checks every client goes through: verify identity, understand the purpose of the account, rate the risk.

- **Enhanced Due Diligence** — deeper checks for higher-risk clients (complex ownership, high-risk countries), including proving **source of wealth** and getting senior sign-off.
- **Ultimate Beneficial Owner** — the real human being(s) who ultimately own or control a company, even when it hides behind layers of other companies (usually anyone owning 25% or more). Finding them stops criminals hiding behind shell companies.
- **Politically Exposed Person** — someone in a prominent public position (a senior official, politician, or their close family), who carries a higher bribery/corruption risk and so gets the deeper checks — not an automatic "no."
- **Sanctions screening** — checking clients and their payments against government "banned" lists (for example, the United States list run by a body called OFAC), so the bank never deals with sanctioned people, companies or countries.
- **Transaction monitoring and Suspicious Activity Reports** — software watches the flow of payments for suspicious patterns; when something looks wrong, the bank files a confidential report with the authorities — and must never tip off the customer.
- **Perpetual Know Your Customer** — the modern approach: instead of re-checking a client every one, three or five years, the bank monitors continuously and re-checks automatically the moment something changes (a new owner, a sanctions hit, bad news in the media).

How onboarding actually runs, step by step INFERRED — standard model[20]

1. The **Relationship Manager collects** the client's documents and explains the expected activity.
2. **Verify the company exists** and is genuine (registry checks, licences).
3. **Map the ownership** all the way up to the real owners — the hardest, slowest step for complex international groups.
4. **Screen** the company, its owners and directors against sanctions and politically-exposed-person lists and adverse news.
5. **Rate the risk** (low, medium, high) from country, industry, product and customer type.
6. **Do enhanced checks** on anything higher-risk.
7. **Run the credit assessment** in parallel.
8. **Approve or decline** — higher-risk cases go to Compliance / Financial Crime.
9. **Monitor continuously** afterwards.

Who does what — the "three lines of defence" INFERRED — standard model

- **First line — the Relationship Manager (front office):** owns the client and is **personally accountable for the risk they bring in.** They collect the information and care about getting the client live quickly.

- **Second line — Compliance and Financial Crime:** set the rules, run the sanctions and anti-money-laundering framework, and can **approve or veto** a client.
- **Middle-office onboarding teams** do the document-checking and screening in between; **Internal Audit (third line)** independently tests that it all works.

Why this matters to the Relationship Manager — and why it's a genuine reason to care

For a big client, full onboarding can take **weeks to months.** That's real revenue delayed and a real source of client frustration — and the Relationship Manager sits right between an impatient client and a demanding control function. So a bank that can onboard **accurately *and* quickly** actually **wins and keeps business** — "good know-your-customer" is a competitive advantage, and slow, repetitive checks are a leading reason companies switch banks. INFERRED [21] HSBC specifically claims its 2024 integration **"reduced onboarding times and improved know-your-customer processes."** OFFICIAL — Euromoney citing HSBC[15]

HSBC's own story — the honest reason it takes this seriously

This isn't abstract for HSBC. In **December 2012**, HSBC admitted serious failings and entered a **five-year deferred-prosecution agreement** with the United States Department of Justice, paying about **$1.9 billion** — then the largest anti-money-laundering penalty in United States history. OFFICIAL — Department of Justice[12] The failings were grave: at least **$881 million** of Mexican drug-cartel money laundered through its United States arm, **over $670 billion** of wire transfers from HSBC Mexico left effectively unmonitored, and roughly **$660 million** of sanctions-breaching transactions. OFFICIAL [12] An independent monitor was installed for five years, and investigative journalists later showed the clean-up took years to bite. CORROBORATED — ICIJ[18] Even in **December 2021**, the United Kingdom regulator fined HSBC **£63.9 million** for weak transaction-monitoring between 2010 and 2018. OFFICIAL — Financial Conduct Authority[13]

Why this is a *good* reason to want to work there, honestly told: financial-crime controls are not box-ticking — they are how a bank stops itself being used to move the proceeds of trafficking and corruption, which cause real-world harm. HSBC learned this the hard way, rebuilt its controls, grew its financial-crime teams to several thousand people, and now makes **"fighting financial crime"** part of its identity. OFFICIAL — HSBC[9] A candidate who *gets* this can say something most can't: *"I want to be a relationship manager who wins business the right way — I understand that at HSBC, doing know-your-customer well and fast is both an ethical duty and a commercial edge, and I find that genuinely motivating."* That is a real, defensible answer. *(Nothing here is about avoiding these controls — the whole point is understanding why they exist and must be respected.)*

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6. The technical machine, part two: asset servicing (looking after investors' assets)

The other machine behind the client-facing role — especially for **institutional** clients like pension funds and asset managers — is **asset servicing**, also called **securities services.**

What it is, plainly

When a big investor owns billions of pounds of shares and bonds spread across dozens of countries, someone has to **hold those assets safely, make sure trades complete, collect the income, and handle the paperwork.** That "someone" is a **custodian bank** — and HSBC is one of the world's biggest. INFERRED / CORROBORATED[6] The main jobs: - **Custody (safekeeping)** — holding the investments securely (as electronic records). - **Settlement** — making sure that when the client buys or sells, the shares and the cash actually change hands. The safe method is **"delivery versus payment"**: the securities are handed over **only if** the money is paid at the same instant, so neither side can be cheated. - **Income collection** — gathering the **dividends** (income from shares) and **coupons** (interest from bonds) and passing them to the client. - **Corporate actions** — handling company events like share splits, mergers and **rights issues** (where a company offers existing owners the chance to buy more shares), including chasing the client for a decision before the deadline. - **Fund administration** — for investment funds, calculating the fund's daily price (its **net asset value**, the value per unit that investors buy and sell at).

Why it exists and why HSBC values it

A global fund can't practically connect to every stock exchange and central bank itself, and regulators often *require* an independent custodian to hold a fund's assets separately from its manager (a protection for investors). INFERRED[6] For HSBC the economics are lovely: it is **capital-light** (fees for a service, tying up little of the bank's own money, so a high return), **steady and "annuity-like"** (income recurs month after month, far less jumpy than trading), and **very sticky** (moving trillions of assets to a rival custodian is so painful that clients rarely do). INFERRED, grounded in the figures below[6]

The scale — real numbers

- HSBC held about **$12.9 trillion of clients' assets in custody** at the end of 2025 — **up 21%** in a year. OFFICIAL — HSBC 2025 filing; CORROBORATED — Global Custodian[17]
- It **administered a further ~$6.0 trillion.** OFFICIAL[17]
- It reaches a **custodian network across 96 markets**, with a large **own network in around 39 markets** concentrated in **Asia and the Middle East**, where it is a leader (for example, the

largest provider in Saudi Arabia) — winning **Euromoney's "Asia's Best Bank for Securities Services 2025."** CORROBORATED [16] It isn't the biggest custodian *globally* (American banks lead on total assets), but it is the **dominant network in Asia and the Middle East** — which is exactly HSBC's whole strategic edge.

- It's also pushing into the future with **HSBC Orion**, its own platform for issuing **tokenised (digital) bonds** on modern distributed-ledger technology — including the **world's first multi-currency digital green bond for the Hong Kong government** in 2024. OFFICIAL [8]

How it connects back to the client-facing role

For institutional clients, the **Relationship Manager is the single front door**, and asset servicing is one of the products they coordinate — alongside currency trading and financing — because it all sits inside the same **Markets and Securities Services** team within the division. Winning a custody mandate is gold for a relationship manager, because it makes the relationship **decades-long and deeply embedded** (constant settlements, corporate actions and reporting keep HSBC in the client's daily operations), and it opens the door to selling more (securities lending, currency, financing). And the **network is the pitch**: to a Western investor wanting Asian exposure, or an Asian investor going global, the relationship manager can say *"we're the bank on the ground where you actually want to invest."* INFERRED, grounded in HSBC's structure[16]

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7. So, why work here? (a client-facing person's honest answer)

Pulling it together into something you could genuinely believe and say:

- **The role fits what you enjoy.** The Relationship Manager is the **client-facing owner** of the relationship — commercial, analytical, and built on trust and long-term relationships. If you like being the person clients rely on, this is the seat.
- **HSBC's model makes the client conversation bigger.** Because HSBC can **follow a client across 56 markets as one bank**, the relationship manager isn't selling one product in one country — they're helping a company grow *internationally*, which is a richer, more strategic conversation than a domestic bank can offer. **62% of revenue** already comes from multi-country clients — that's the network doing the work. OFFICIAL [15]
- **The "boring" machinery is actually why you'd trust the place.** Understanding the anti-money-laundering history and the asset-servicing engine shows the role is about **doing business the right way, at scale, over decades** — winning clients quickly *and* cleanly, and keeping them for the long term. That's a mature reason to be drawn to it, not a slogan.

- **It's a growth seat.** This division is the **biggest profit contributor** and the centre of HSBC's future (Asia, trade, payments, wealth connectivity). Joining the client-facing side of *that* is joining the engine room. OFFICIAL [11]

A line you could adapt: *"I like client-facing work because I'm energised by understanding a business and being the person they trust. What draws me to HSBC specifically is that its network turns that into an international, strategic relationship — I'd be helping companies grow across borders, not selling one product in one market. And the more I've read about how HSBC onboards clients and services institutional assets, the more I respect that it's built to do this properly and for the long term."*

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8. Glossary (every technical term in one place)

- **Relationship Manager / coverage banker** — the banker who owns a client relationship and brings in specialists; the client-facing role.
- **Wallet / share of wallet** — how much of a client's total banking business the bank wins.
- **Facility** — a credit arrangement (a loan or line of credit).
- **Covenant** — a promise a borrower makes in a loan (e.g. to keep debt below a set level).
- **Credit application / credit committee** — the written case to lend, and the senior group that approves it.
- **Cross-selling** — selling more products to an existing client.
- **Onboarding** — the process of taking on a new client, including all the checks below.
- **Money laundering** — making crime money look legal; done in three steps: placement, layering, integration.
- **Know Your Customer** — the duty to genuinely know who your client is, and keep knowing.
- **Customer Due Diligence** — the baseline identity-and-risk checks on every client.
- **Enhanced Due Diligence** — deeper checks for higher-risk clients.
- **Ultimate Beneficial Owner** — the real human owner(s) behind a company (usually 25%+ ownership).
- **Politically Exposed Person** — someone in a prominent public role, higher-risk, gets deeper checks.
- **Sanctions screening** — checking clients and payments against government "banned" lists.
- **Transaction monitoring** — software watching payments for suspicious patterns.

- **Suspicious Activity Report** — a confidential report to the authorities about suspected crime (no tipping off the client).
- **Perpetual Know Your Customer** — continuously re-checking clients instead of on a fixed cycle.
- **Three lines of defence** — front office (owns the risk), compliance (sets and polices the rules), internal audit (independently tests both).
- **Asset servicing / securities services** — safekeeping and administering investors' assets.
- **Custodian bank** — a bank that holds investors' assets safely and handles the paperwork.
- **Custody / safekeeping** — holding investments securely as electronic records.
- **Settlement** — completing a trade so securities and cash change hands.
- **Delivery versus payment** — settlement where securities move only if cash is paid at the same instant.
- **Dividend / coupon** — income from a share / interest from a bond.
- **Corporate action** — a company event (split, merger, rights issue) the custodian must process.
- **Rights issue** — a company offering existing owners the chance to buy more shares.
- **Net asset value** — a fund's per-unit price, at which investors buy and sell.
- **Fund administration / transfer agency** — calculating a fund's value / keeping its register of owners.
- **Capital-light** — a business that earns fees without tying up much of the bank's own money (a high return).
- **Tokenised / digital bond** — a bond issued as a secure digital record on modern ledger technology (HSBC's platform is called Orion).
- **Transition finance / decarbonise** — funding to help clients cut their carbon emissions.

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9. What I've simplified or couldn't fully verify

- The **numbered client lifecycle** is the standard industry process; HSBC doesn't publish its own stage-by-stage version, so treat it as "how it works," not an official HSBC playbook.
- HSBC does **not publish the number of relationship managers** or revenue-per-client — honest gaps.
- **Market counts vary by HSBC page** (about 56 banking markets; 175 for payments). I've used "around 56 markets" for the bank and flagged payments separately.
- **2025 revenue figures** (the ~$27–28 billion division revenue and ~$10.9 billion transaction-banking figure) came through summaries of HSBC's latest results; the rock-solid number is the

first-half-2025 **$14.1 billion** of divisional revenue — verify the full-year figures in HSBC's annual report before quoting exact decimals.[11]

- The **compliance-staffing numbers** (grown to several thousand) come from press reporting, not a single official figure — say "several thousand," not a precise count.
- **Asset-servicing revenue** for 2025 was reported as "broadly flat"; the exact figure wasn't confirmed from a primary source.

Source list

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Compiled 10 August 2026. HSBC's own descriptions and the regulator documents are quoted directly; the client lifecycle is the standard industry process; and the most recent revenue figures should be checked against HSBC's latest results before you quote exact numbers.

Self-contained briefing · rendered from `hsbc-assessment-briefing.md` · 8 August 2026. Reliability labels reflect the evidence at that date; HSBC's process changes frequently.